

Two words or one?

Some words in the English language are often used together, so it's easy to mistake them for a single word. Here are some phrases that many people fall into the trap of writing as one word instead of two.

a lot
bath time
blood sugar
cash flow
first aid

full time
hard copy
high chair
hip bone
home page

ice cream
life cycle
never mind
post office
race car

real time
seat belt
side effect
time frame
time sheet

Commonly confused words

The English language is full of similar-sounding words that have different meanings. It is essential, therefore, to spell the words correctly to achieve the correct meaning

accept and except

I **accept** your apology.
Everyone was on the list **except** for me.

adverse and averse

She was feeling unwell due to the **adverse** effects of her medication.
He was lazy and **averse** to playing sports.

aisle and isle

The bride walked down the **aisle**.
They visited an **isle** near the coast of Scotland.

aloud and allowed

She read the book **aloud**.
He was **allowed** to choose which book to read.

amoral and immoral

Her **amoral** attitude meant that she didn't care if her actions were wrong.
He was fired from the company for **immoral** conduct.

appraise and apprise

The manager needed to **appraise** the employee's skills.
The lawyer arrived to **apprise** the defendant of his rights.

assent and ascent

He nodded his **assent**.
They watched the **ascent** of the balloon.

aural and oral

The **aural** test required her to listen.
The dentist performed an **oral** examination.

bare and bear

She went outside with **bare** feet.
The large **bear** roamed the woods.

in a sentence. Here are some of the most commonly confused words that sound alike, with examples of their correct usage.

break and brake

The chocolate was easy to **break** apart.
The car didn't **brake** fast enough.

broach and brooch

He decided to **broach** the subject for discussion.
She wore a pretty **brooch**.

capital and capitol

Richmond is the **capital** of Virginia.
The state **capitol** is an impressive building.

cereal and serial

He ate a bowl of **cereal** for breakfast.
She found the **serial** number on her computer.

complement and compliment

The colors **complement** each other well.
He paid her a **compliment** by telling her she was pretty.

cue and queue

The actor waited for his **cue** before walking on stage.
There are three jobs left in the printer **queue**.

desert and dessert

The **desert** is extremely hot and dry.
She decided to have cake for **dessert**.

pore and pour

He had a blocked **pore** on his nose.
She helped **pour** the drinks at the party.

principle and principal

The man was guided by strong **principles**.
He was given the role of the **principal** character.

stationary and stationery

The aircraft landed and remained **stationary**.
She looked in the **stationery** cabinet for a pen.